

Word family: **tense / tenser / tensest / tensely / tenseness / tension**

Base word: tense

Part of speech: mainly **adjective** and **noun**, also **verb**

Related forms:

* **tense** (adj.) — 緊張的；繃緊的；緊繃的

* **tense** (n.) — 時態

* **tense** (v.) — 使繃緊；變得緊張 / 繃緊

* **tensely** (adv.) — 緊張地；繃緊地

* **tenseness** (n.) — 緊張狀態；繃緊程度

* **tension** (n.) — 緊張；張力；矛盾；拉力

* **tensional** (adj., specialist/rare) — 與張力有關的；一般學習者毋須主動使用

Useful expressions / extensions:

* **feel tense**

* **become / get tense**

* **tense atmosphere**

* **tense situation**

* **tense relationship**

* **tense silence**

* **tense muscles**

* **tense your muscles**

* **tense up**

* **past tense**

* **present tense**

* **future tense**

* **tension between**

* **political / social tension**

* **muscle tension**

* **surface tension**

* **under tension**

* **ease / reduce tension**

* **build-up of tension**

Meaning in this passage

> The deadline was breathing down our necks, so everyone was tired, **tense**, and a little irritable.

Here, **tense** means:

**anxious, stressed, and unable to relax because of pressure — 緊張的；繃緊的；精神緊繃的

Everyone was under deadline pressure, so they were emotionally on edge.

**中文翻譯： **

截止日期已經逼在眼前，所以大家都很累、很**緊張 / 精神繃緊**，也有點容易煩躁。

So here:

tense = 因壓力、擔心或衝突而精神不能放鬆

1. **tense (緊張的；精神繃緊的) — 緊張的；繃緊的**

This is the exact sense used in your passage.

Practice 1 — original sentence

> Everyone was tired, **tense**, and a little irritable.

大家都很累、很**緊張**，也有點容易煩躁。

Practice 2

> I always feel **tense** before an important presentation.

重要簡報前，我總會感到很**緊張**。

Practice 3

> She looked **tense** while waiting for the results.

她等候結果時看起來很**精神繃緊**。

MCQ-ready definition:

tense = 因壓力、憂慮或不安而無法放鬆的

2. **feel / look / sound tense — 感到 / 看起來 / 聽起來緊張**

Practice 1

> You **look tense**. Is everything okay?

你看起來很**緊張**。沒事吧？

Practice 2

> His voice **sounded tense**.

他的聲音聽起來很**繃緊 / 緊張**。

MCQ-ready definition:

look/sound tense = 從表情、姿勢或聲音中顯示出緊張和壓力

3. **get / become tense — 變得緊張**

Practice 1

> Everyone **became tense** as the deadline approached.

隨着截止日期逼近，大家都**變得緊張**。

Practice 2

> The room suddenly **got tense**.

房間裏的氣氛突然**緊張起來**。

MCQ-ready definition:

get/become tense = 從較放鬆的狀態轉為緊張或繃緊

4. **tense atmosphere — 緊張氣氛**

Here **tense** describes the situation rather than one person.

Practice 1

> There was a **tense atmosphere** in the meeting.

會議中瀰漫着**緊張氣氛**。

Practice 2

> His angry comment created a **tense atmosphere**.

他憤怒的評論令現場氣氛變得**緊張**。

MCQ-ready definition:

tense atmosphere = 大家因衝突、壓力或不確定性而感到不安的氣氛

5. **tense situation** — 緊張局面

Practice 1

> The manager tried to calm the **tense situation**.

經理嘗試緩和**緊張局面**。

Practice 2

> It was a **tense situation**, but nobody raised their voice.

當時局面很**緊張**，但沒有人提高聲線。

MCQ-ready definition:

tense situation = 充滿壓力、衝突或可能出現問題的情況

6. **tense relationship** — 關係緊張

Practice 1

> Their relationship became **tense** after the argument.

爭吵後，他們的關係變得**緊張**。

Practice 2

> Relations between the two departments were **tense**.

兩個部門之間的關係很**緊張**。

MCQ-ready definition:

tense relationship = 雙方存在不滿、衝突或戒心，難以自然相處的關係

7. **tense silence — 緊張的沉默**

Practice 1

> A **tense silence** followed his accusation.

他指責完後，現場陷入一片**緊張的沉默**。

Practice 2

> They sat in **tense silence**.

他們在**緊張而尷尬的沉默**中坐着。

MCQ-ready definition:

tense silence = 因衝突、不安或期待而令人感到壓力的沉默

8. **tense (肌肉繃緊的) — 繃緊的；僵硬的**

A major physical sense.

Practice 1

> My shoulders felt **tense** after hours at the computer.

長時間用電腦後，我的肩膀感到很**繃緊**。

Practice 2

> His muscles were **tense**.

他的肌肉**繃得很緊**。

MCQ-ready definition:

tense = muscles/body held tight rather than relaxed

中文：

肌肉處於收緊、僵硬而沒有放鬆的狀態

9. **tense your muscles — 繃緊 / 收緊肌肉**

Here **tense** is a verb.

Practice 1

> **Tense** your stomach muscles for a few seconds.

把腹部肌肉**收緊**幾秒。

Practice 2

> He **tensed** his shoulders when he heard the noise.

他聽到聲音時，肩膀立刻**繃緊**。

MCQ-ready definition:

tense a muscle/body part = deliberately or automatically make the muscles tight

10. **tense up** — 繃緊；緊張起來

A highly useful phrasal extension.

Practice 1

> I always **tense up** before speaking in public.

我每次公開說話前都會**緊張起來** / 全身**繃緊**。

Practice 2

> Don't **tense up**—try to relax your shoulders.

不要**繃得那麼緊**，試着放鬆肩膀。

MCQ-ready definition:

tense up = become physically or emotionally tight because of fear, pressure, or nervousness

11. **tensely** — 緊張地；繃緊地

Practice 1

> They waited **tensely** for the announcement.

他們**緊張地**等待公布結果。

Practice 2

> “What happened?” she asked **tensely**.

「發生了甚麼？」她**緊張地**問。

MCQ-ready definition:

tensely = 以顯得緊張、不安或繃緊的方式

12. **tenseness — 緊張狀態；繃緊**

Less common than **tension**.

Practice 1

> I could feel the **tenseness** in his shoulders.

我能感覺到他肩膀的**繃緊**。

Practice 2

> The **tenseness** in the room slowly disappeared.

房間裏的**緊張感**慢慢消失。

MCQ-ready definition:

tenseness = the state or quality of being tense

Usage note: In most contexts, **tension** is considerably more natural.

13. **tense (grammar : 時態) — 時態**

A completely separate noun sense.

Practice 1

> This sentence is in the past **tense**.

這個句子使用過去**時態**。

Practice 2

> Which **tense** should I use here?

我這裏應該用哪個**時態**？

MCQ-ready definition:

tense = 文法上用來表示事件或狀態與時間關係的一種形式或系統

14. **past tense** — 過去時態

Practice 1

> The story is written mainly in the **past tense**.

這個故事主要使用**過去時態**寫成。

Practice 2

> Change the verb into the **past tense**.

把動詞改成**過去式 / 過去時態**。

MCQ-ready definition:

past tense = 表示過去時間或過去情況的文法時態

15. **present tense** — 現在時態

Practice 1

> The writer suddenly switches to the **present tense**.

作者突然轉用**現在時態**。

Practice 2

> Use the **present tense** for general facts.

描述一般事實時使用**現在時態**。

MCQ-ready definition:

****present tense = 通常用來表示現在、習慣或一般事實的時態****

16. ****future tense — 未來時態****

Practice 1

> Students often call “will + verb” the ****future tense****.

學生常把「will + 動詞」稱為****未來時態****。

Practice 2

> Different languages express future time in different ways rather than always having one grammatical ****future tense****.

不同語言表達未來時間的方法不同，並非所有語言都有單一的文法****未來時態****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****future tense = 表達未來時間的時態或文法形式；不同文法分析對英文的分類方式可能不同****

17. ****tension (緊張；緊張氣氛) — 緊張；不安****

This is the major noun relative.

Practice 1

> There was obvious ****tension**** in the room.

房間裏有明顯的****緊張氣氛****。

Practice 2

> The joke helped reduce the ****tension****.

那個笑話有助****緩和緊張氣氛****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****tension = 因壓力、不安、衝突或不確定性造成的緊張狀態****

18. ****tension between people / groups — 人際 / 群體間的緊張關係****

Practice 1

> There was growing **tension between the two teammates**.

兩名隊員之間的**緊張關係**愈來愈嚴重。

Practice 2

> The disagreement created **tension between the departments**.

這次分歧令兩個部門之間出現**緊張關係**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****tension between A and B = 因不信任、衝突或分歧而產生的敵意或不安****

19. **political / social tension — 政治 / 社會緊張局勢**

Practice 1

> Social **tensions** increased after the incident.

事件後，社會**緊張局勢**升溫。

Practice 2

> The agreement helped ease political **tension**.

該協議有助緩和政治**緊張局勢**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****political/social tension = 社會群體、機構或政治力量之間的衝突與緊張狀態****

20. **muscle tension — 肌肉繃緊；肌肉緊張**

Practice 1

> Stress can cause **muscle tension**.

壓力可以導致**肌肉繃緊**。

Practice 2

> Stretching can reduce **muscle tension**.

伸展運動可以減少**肌肉緊張**。

MCQ-ready definition:

muscle tension = 肌肉持續收緊、不能完全放鬆的狀態

21. **tension (物理：張力；拉力) — 張力；拉力**

A major scientific/technical sense.

Practice 1

> The rope is under considerable **tension**.

繩子承受相當大的**張力**。

Practice 2

> Too much **tension** may cause the cable to break.

過大的**拉力**可能令纜索斷裂。

MCQ-ready definition:

tension = a pulling force transmitted through a rope, cable, string, or similar material

中文：

物件被兩端拉扯時所承受的拉力或張力

22. **under tension — 受拉力；處於繃緊狀態**

Practice 1

> The cable remains **under tension**.

纜索一直處於**受拉狀態**。

Practice 2

> Never cut a rope that is **under tension**.

不要切斷正在承受**拉力**的繩索。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****under tension = being pulled tight by opposing forces****

23. ****surface tension — 表面張力****

A common science sense.

Practice 1

> Water has relatively high ****surface tension****.

水具有相對較高的****表面張力****。

Practice 2

> Soap reduces the ****surface tension**** of water.

肥皂會降低水的****表面張力****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****surface tension = 液體表面因分子間作用而產生、像薄膜般的收縮作用****

24. ****tension (戲劇 / 故事中的緊張感) — 緊張感 ; 懸念****

Practice 1

> The director builds ****tension**** slowly throughout the film.

導演在整套電影中逐步營造****緊張感****。

Practice 2

> The silence increased the ****tension**** in the scene.

沉默增加了場景中的****緊張感 / 懸念****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****tension = 故事或表演中因不確定、危險或衝突而產生的緊張期待感****

25. **build tension** — 營造 / 加劇緊張感

Practice 1

> The music helps **build tension**.

音樂有助**營造緊張感**。

Practice 2

> The argument gradually **built tension** within the group.

爭論逐漸**加劇了組內的緊張氣氛**。

MCQ-ready definition:

build tension = 令緊張、衝突或懸念逐步增加

26. **ease / reduce tension** — 緩和緊張

Practice 1

> His apology **eased the tension**.

他的道歉**緩和了緊張氣氛**。

Practice 2

> She made a joke to **reduce the tension**.

她說了個笑話來**緩和緊張感**。

MCQ-ready definition:

ease/reduce tension = 令緊張、衝突或身體繃緊程度下降

27. **tension between competing ideas / needs** — 兩者之間的矛盾 / 拉扯

An important abstract use.

Practice 1

> There is a **tension** between speed and accuracy.

速度和準確性之間存在一種**矛盾 / 拉扯**。

Practice 2

> The policy reflects the **tension** between privacy and convenience.

這項政策反映私隱與便利之間的**張力 / 矛盾**。

MCQ-ready definition:

tension between X and Y = 兩種彼此難以完全兼容的目標、價值或需要之間的拉扯

Important distinction 1: **tense** vs **nervous**

Very important for your sentence.

nervous

often focuses on anxiety about what may happen.

tense

focuses on being unable to relax because of pressure, anxiety, or conflict.

> nervous before an interview

> 面試前緊張

> tense after hours of deadline pressure

> 在期限壓力下精神繃緊

In your passage, **tense** fits especially well because the stress has been building across the whole group.

Important distinction 2: **tense** vs **stressed**

stressed

feeling pressure because demands are difficult to handle.

tense

the resulting state of emotional or physical tightness.

Someone can be:

> stressed and tense

= 有壓力，而且整個人繃得很緊

They overlap but are not identical.

Important distinction 3: **tense** vs **anxious**

anxious

focuses on worry, fear, or unease.

tense

focuses on inability to relax.

An anxious person will often become tense, but **tense** can also arise from anger or conflict rather than worry.

Important distinction 4: **tense** vs **irritable**

Your passage deliberately lists both:

> tired, tense, and a little irritable

tense

緊張、繃緊

irritable

容易煩躁、容易發脾氣

Being tense may make someone irritable, but they are different emotional states.

Important distinction 5: **tense** vs **tight**

tight

physically firmly stretched/fitted/compressed.

tense

can describe muscles, but also emotions and situations.

> tight trousers

緊身褲

> tense muscles

繃緊的肌肉

> tense atmosphere

緊張氣氛

You cannot normally say *tight atmosphere* with the same meaning.

Important distinction 6: **tense muscles vs stiff muscles**

tense

actively or emotionally tightened.

stiff

hard to move, often from injury, inactivity, or soreness.

> tense shoulders from stress

因壓力而肩膀繃緊

> stiff neck after sleeping badly

睡姿不好後頸部僵硬

Important distinction 7: **tense adjective vs tense verb**

Adjective

> My shoulders are tense.

我的肩膀很繃緊。

Verb

> I tensed my shoulders.

我把肩膀繃緊。

And:

> My shoulders tensed.

我的肩膀繃緊起來。

Important distinction 8: **tense up vs calm down**

They are almost directional opposites in emotional/physical state:

tense up

變得繃緊 / 緊張

calm down / relax

冷靜 / 放鬆

Important distinction 9: **tense = 緊張 vs tense = 時態**

These are completely separate learner senses.

Adjective

> I feel tense.

我感到緊張。

Noun

> Which tense is this?

這是甚麼時態？

Context and part of speech determine the meaning.

Important distinction 10: **tense vs time in grammar**

time

actual chronological concept:

- * past
- * present
- * future

tense

grammatical marking/form.

They are related, but not identical.

A language can express future **time** without necessarily using a dedicated morphological future **tense**.

Important distinction 11: **tense vs aspect**

A useful grammar distinction.

tense

locates a situation relative to time.

aspect

describes how an event unfolds or is viewed:

- * ongoing
- * completed
- * repeated, etc.

For example, in traditional learner grammar:

> was working

often combines **past** time/tense with **progressive aspect**.

Important distinction 12: **tension vs tenseness**

tension

far more common and broader:

* emotional tension

* political tension

* muscle tension

* physical tension

tenseness

simply the quality/state of being tense and is less idiomatic in most contexts.

Usually choose **tension**.

Important distinction 13: **tension = emotional vs physical**

Emotional

> tension in the meeting

會議中的緊張氣氛

Physical

> tension in the cable

纜索中的張力

A major polysemy split.

Important distinction 14: **tension = conflict vs disagreement**

disagreement

people hold different views.

tension

the strained atmosphere or relationship that may result.

People can disagree politely without tension.

Important distinction 15: **tension vs suspense**

suspense

uncertainty about what will happen, especially in stories.

tension

the emotional strain created by uncertainty/conflict.

A suspenseful film often builds tension.

Important distinction 16: **tension between A and B vs balance between A and B**

tension

the two goals pull against each other.

balance

an appropriate relationship between them has been achieved.

> tension between speed and quality

> 速度與質素之間的矛盾

> balance between speed and quality

> 速度與質素之間的平衡

Family-extension note

****Tense**** has three especially important modern branches:

1. **emotional tension**

- * feel tense
- * tense atmosphere
- * tense relationship

2. **physical tightness**

- * tense muscles
- * tense your shoulders
- * tense up

3. **grammar**

- * past tense
- * present tense

Its major noun relative ****tension**** then expands into:

4. **psychological/social strain**

- * tension in the room
- * tension between people

5. **story suspense**

- * build tension

6. **physical force**

- * rope under tension
- * surface tension

7. **abstract conflict**

- * tension between two competing goals

The underlying connection between many non-grammar senses is:

**something being stretched tight rather than relaxed**

That physical idea becomes a powerful metaphor for people and relationships under pressure.

Master comparison

Form / expression	Traditional Chinese	Core idea
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tense (person)	緊張的；精神繃緊的	unable to relax
feel tense	感到緊張	emotional state
look/sound tense	看 / 聽起來緊張	visible/audible state
get tense	變得緊張	change of state
tense atmosphere	緊張氣氛	strained environment
tense situation	緊張局面	pressured situation
tense relationship	緊張關係	strained relationship
tense silence	緊張的沉默	pressured silence
tense muscles	繃緊的肌肉	physical tightness
tense your muscles	收緊肌肉	verb
tense up	緊張 / 繃緊起來	become tense
tensely	緊張地	manner
tenseness	緊張 / 繃緊狀態	quality
tense (grammar)	時態	grammatical time system
past tense	過去時態	past
present tense	現在時態	present
future tense	未來時態	future expression
tension	緊張；張力	state/force
tension between people	人際緊張	strained relations
political/social tension	政治 / 社會緊張	conflict
muscle tension	肌肉緊張	tight muscles
under tension	受拉力	pulling force
surface tension	表面張力	liquid physics
build tension	營造 / 加劇緊張感	increase strain
ease tension	緩和緊張	reduce strain
tension between X and Y	X 與 Y 之間的矛盾 / 拉扯	competing demands

For your original sentence

> The deadline was breathing down our necks, so everyone was tired, ****tense****, and a little irritable.

Here:

****tense = 因截止期限的壓力而精神繃緊、無法放鬆****

A natural Traditional Chinese rendering is:

> 截止日期已經逼在眼前，所以大家都很累、很**緊張**，也有點容易煩躁。

The three adjectives describe different layers nicely:

* **tired** → 身體 / 精神疲累

* **tense** → 壓力下精神繃緊

* **irritable** → 因疲勞和壓力而變得容易煩躁

So for this passage, **「緊張 / 精神繃緊」** is much more accurate than interpreting **tense** as the grammar sense **「時態」**.